

WHEN THE BEAUTIFUL GAME TURNED UGLY

From visa restrictions and geopolitical tensions to VAR controversies and refereeing disputes, a look at the **biggest flashpoints** of the 2026 FIFA World Cup.

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Controversy has always found a way to seep into the FIFA World Cup.

From Diego Maradona's 'Hand of God' to the 'Disgrace of Gijón' to Luis Suarez turning emergency goalkeeper against Ghana, the greatest show on Earth has produced countless talking points that have dragged on for years.

This time, geopolitical tensions and a lack of clarity from the authorities running the tournament ensured opinions remained divided.

The fault lines first appeared when Somalian referee Omar Artan was denied the chance to become the first match official from his country to officiate at the World Cup. Just days before the tournament began, Artan, named Africa's best referee last year, was stopped at Miami International Airport by the United States Customs and Border Protection (CBP). The agency deemed him inadmissible due to "vetting concerns."

However, there was some solace for Artan. He not only received the full payment he was entitled to but was also announced as the referee for August's UEFA Super Cup tie between Paris Saint-Germain and Aston Villa in Salzburg, Austria.

Meanwhile, Iran emerged as the biggest casualty of the visa restrictions, forced to shift its base camp from Tucson, Arizona, to Tijuana, Mexico because of the war in the Middle East.

That came despite all three of Iran's group-stage

matches being scheduled in the United States after FIFA rejected its request for relocation. The situation only worsened once the tournament began. For the first two matches, U.S. authorities allowed the players to enter the country only within 24 hours of kick-off, following extensive security checks. They were then required to return to their training camp almost immediately after full-time, disrupting their normal recovery routine.

Iran was granted an extra day for its final group game, but the pressure had already taken its toll. Three draws saw it exit in the group stage for the seventh time, prompting head coach Amir Ghalenoei to speak out.

"It was the host that wasn't very good to us," Ghalenoei said, referring to the Donald Trump-governed host nation, before adding: "I urge FIFA to not let the hosts treat teams and players the same way in the future. I hope Mr (Gianni) Infantino will actually stand up to such behaviour."

Turning to events on the pitch, VAR remained at the centre of controversy, particularly in